



because you can replace only the cartridge that runs out first. It comes with specially-formulated ink that Epson claims to be water-resistant, and fade-resistant up to 80 years. A slight accident in the Test Centre proved that the printouts really are water-resistant.

The drivers are full-fledged, and allow for maintenance of the cartridges, etc. Another nice feature is support for both the parallel and USB interfaces.

It has a foldable paper-out tray, which fits nicely with the body when folded back. The translucent cartridge bay flap hides the cartridges, and also adds a touch of style to the otherwise bland plastic body. The paper capacity is around 120 sheets.

At Rs. 4,750, it's the most expensive in this segment. If you need a printer with decent output quality, and one that can do bulk text prints, look for the Epson Stylus C63 as a potential deskmate.

Epson Stylus C63		C
Performance	    	
Features	    	
Build quality	    	
Overall	    	

- + Good features, water-resistant ink
- Just decent quality printouts, a tad expensive

HP Deskjet 3550

The hippie

The HP Deskjet 3550 was neck and neck with the Canon xnu i255 in dishing out prints. In text printout at normal mode, the 3550 was faster than the i255 by 4 seconds. However, when the same file was printed in Best mode, the HP 3550 was almost four times slower than the Canon i255, the reason being its USB 2.0 interface.



Similarly, when the combi-document was printed in Normal mode, the HP 3550 did the job faster, but was beaten by the Canon i255 in Best printing mode.

One thing that will scare away potential buyers is the cost per page. A single black page sets you back by Rs 6, and a colour page works out to about Rs 4.

Both the HP 3550 and the Canon i255 set themselves apart from the rest of the crowd when it comes to print quality. The printed text document is as good as the ones from laser printers. Images printed from the HP 3550 were crisp, vibrant and all colours were reproduced truly. Contrast and brightness were optimum, despite the fact that no image enhancements from the driver were used.

The successor to the HP 3325, the HP 3550 comes very close to being the ideal home printer. Smaller than the Canon i255, the HP 3550 is better engineered. While Canon sacrificed on several functional things, such as the output tray on its i255, HP has built the 3550 to be small, but fully functional.

With the off-white and grey plastic panel, this printer had the best looks amongst all those compared. The foldable paper input tray tucks away under the ink cartridge bay. The same tray also functions as the output tray, and hence, human inter-

vention is required at times to separate printed papers from blank ones. The HP 3550 supports the USB 1.1 interface, but not the parallel interface. Installing the printer is easy, and the drivers offer good functionality. The ink-status monitor is the best amongst the lot in terms of accuracy and legibility.

Priced at Rs 2,999 plus taxes, the HP Deskjet 3550 is a good buy, considering its all round capabilities in terms of performance and quality, but do bear in mind that it has a high running cost. For a home where printing is irregular, this printer will do the job best.

HP Deskjet 3550		B
Performance	    	
Features	    	
Build quality	    	
Overall	    	

- + Quite cheap, good photo-printing capability
- High cost per page

HP Deskjet 3650

The HP Deskjet 3650 was no firecracker when it came to pure speed, but met the best of the crowd at eye-level. It was better than the HP 3550 in the text, combi-document and image printout speed tests. However, it certainly is no match to the superior Canon i255 that beat the hide out of it when it comes to printing heavy documents such as the image printout.



Quality was one aspect where the HP 3550 beat the HP 3650 hands down. Whether it's text documents or a full blown image printout, the HP 3550 yields better prints than the HP 3650. Both the printers reproduced every minute detail of the test photograph. The only parameter where the HP 3550 beat it is in colour reproduction. Like its younger sibling, the HP 3650 is an ink guzzler, and a single page of black will cost you Rs 4.50; a colour page costs Rs 4.

The HP 3650 attempts to look like a SoHo printer—everything right from the colour to the design, attempts to imitate a business look. But this attempt to be an office solution stops with its looks—the paper capacity of only 100 sheets and its features sends it back to the home segment. It comes with separate foldable paper tray for input and output, which neatly tucks away inside the cartridge bay. The separate output paper tray solves the paper problem associated with the HP 3550. Like its younger sibling, the HP 3650 interfaces with the PC via USB 1.1.

Installation was a breeze with no hassles. The driver remains the same for both the printers, as do the utilities that come bundled with them. The ink-status monitor is accurate.

Priced at Rs 3,999, the HP Deskjet 3650 offers good looks, decent performance and equally good print quality. But the Rs 1,000 difference between its price and that of the HP 3550 just for the design is unjustifiable.

HP Deskjet 3650		C-
Performance	     	
Features	     	
Ease of use	     	
Value for money	     	

- + Great looks and decent output
- Tad expensive for its features

